# PLAYMAKER

OPEN YOUR EYES

*"Every possession asks one question: what is the best shot you can create before the clock runs out? Read the floor. Find the mismatch. Make the extra pass."*

2 PLAYERS · 12+ AGE · 30–60 MINUTES

DESIGN: SHAUN BARTLETT

## Aim of the game

Two players, two possessions. Each player attacks once and defends once.

You have 12 seconds to build the best shot you can. Shots are never rolled: a shot scores what it was worth. The higher score wins.

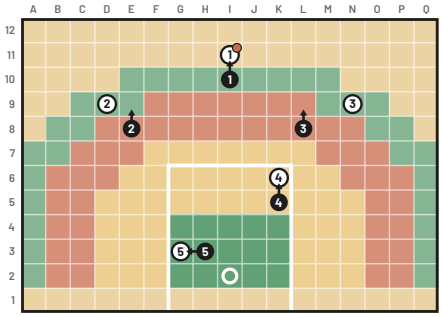
So reading the floor beats luck. Find the open player, the mismatch, the right moment to shoot.

## In the box

| Component | What it's for |
|---|---|
| Court board | Where you play. It also shows shot zones, the shot clock and key rules. |
| 2 trackers | One for offence, one for defence. **Every action's rules are printed here.** |
| 75 player cards | Offence ratings on the front, defence on the back. |
| 10 player pieces | 5 white O (screen T on the back), 5 black X with an arrow. |
| 12 action tokens | 6 white, 6 black. One token is one action. |
| 8 lock tokens | Mark a player who can't Move, Sprint or Dribble this phase. |
| Ball and d20 | The ball sits on the ball carrier. |
| Shot clock marker | Counts down the 12 seconds. |
| Score book | For scores, fouls and turnovers. |
| First-game guides and playbook | Optional. Worked examples and plays to try. |

## Setup

1. Each player takes 5 player cards, one per position. First game: a prescribed team. More options: Playing levels.
2. Roll the d20. The higher roll attacks first and sits on the **left**, with the offence tracker.
3. Put the shot clock marker on **12**.
4. The offence places its 5 O pieces anywhere. The ball goes on a player standing on plain wood beyond the three-point tiles.
5. The defence places its 5 X pieces on empty squares. Point each arrow any way you like.
6. Each player puts their 6 action tokens in their tracker's action pool.




*A typical start. Squares are named by column and row, like I11.*

**Choose with the marks, then do the sum**

Your mark v theirs:

| | |
|---|---|
| ▲ v ▼ | Always great. |
| **Plain v plain** | Okay if nothing better. |
| ▼ v ▲ | Only with a lucky roll. |

## The shot

Every shot is worth:

**Shot value**

**points × (rating − contest)**

**Points**: 2 or 3, from the tile the shooter stands on.
**Rating**: the shooter's card rating for that shot.
**Contest**: the contesting defender's rating against it.

**Example**: a shooter rated 13 from mid-range, contested by a 4: 2 × (13 − 4) = **18**.

## Reading the court

The coloured tiles show the points for a shot from that square.

| | |
|---|---|
| 2 | Layup, dunk, post move |
| 3 | Three-pointer |
| 2 | Mid-range, floater |
| 2 | Long two |
| – | Plain wood: no shot |

## Rolling

Roll the d20. You **succeed** on **equal to or under** your rating minus theirs.
Pass 15 v Intercept 7: 8 or less.

## Playing a possession

The possession is played in **phases** of 2 seconds. Repeat these steps until someone shoots or the clock runs out.

### 1. Take turns

The offence goes first. Then the teams take turns. On your turn, take **1 or 2 actions**.

To take an action, move an action token from your pool into the player's slot on your tracker. Your tracker explains each action.

Actions below the black bar **end your turn**. Play them last. Each team gets **one Pause** (defence) or **one Hesitate** (offence) a phase.

### 2. End the phase

The phase ends when:

- the offence plays its last token. The defence gets one more turn first.
- the defence plays its last token. It ends at once.
- a shot is taken.

### 3. Reset

Put all action tokens back in the pools. Remove lock tokens. Move the shot clock down 2. Players stay where they are.

If the clock reaches **0** before a shot: **turnover, –5**, and the ball carrier takes a forced shot from where the pieces stand, contested as normal. Plain wood, or a value below 0, scores 0.

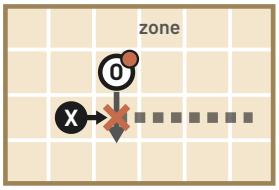
## Screens

Any player except the ball carrier. A Screen is the turn's first action, or its second straight after that player's own Move, and it ends the turn. It lasts until the screener moves, a Challenge beats it, or the phase ends.

## Defender arrows

Each X piece points an arrow. **Next to** always includes diagonals.

A defender's **zone** is the squares along his arrow that one movement could reach. It stops at the first player in the way, and shrinks once he has used his Move.



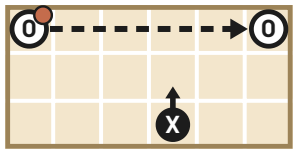

*The ball carrier can't drive through the zone of a defender next to him.*

- **Drives**: the ball carrier may step into the zone of a defender next to him, but not through it, unless he wins a Dribble.
- **Arrow on the ball carrier**: the defender can Steal, and contests cleanly.
- **Steal**: closer to the rim than the ball carrier, one foul roll; level or behind, two, and either fouls. A Steal that misses without a foul locks you.

## Passes and intercepts

A pass fixes a line from passer to receiver. The defence answers with its **first action**, or the pass lands.

- **Through you**: the line passes through your square's centre. Intercept, whatever your facing.
- **Jump the lane**: one straight Move, Quick Step or Sprint along your arrow, keeping your facing, whose path touches or crosses the line. Then Intercept. That's your whole turn.
- **Next to the passer**: no intercept on any square around him. Steal instead.
- **Denied**: no pass through the square of a defender next to the receiver.




*Jump the lane: X steps straight along his arrow onto the pass.*

Roll ≤ Pass – Intercept. A miss leaves him on the line, Move used.

## Shooting

Declare a Shot. The defence reacts with up to 2 actions from its tokens. The last may be a **Contest**: 1 token, one defender next to the shooter. Sprint, then Contest, closes out.

Arrow off the shooter: foul roll first, once if the contester is closer to the rim than the shooter, twice if level or further. Further: contest at **–3**. Count squares to the rim; the rings show it.

## Scoring

| What happened | Score |
|---|---|
| Intercept or steal | –5, lose 2 seconds, play on. A stolen shot is cancelled. Last phase: 0, or the score so far if lower |
| Foul on a steal | +5, play on |
| Second foul on a steal | +5 and free throws, possession ends |
| Foul on a shot, a Steal's too | Free throws or the open shot, whichever is higher; possession ends |
| Shot clock hits 0 | Forced shot as they stand, –5 |

**Free throws** score 2 × the shooter's FT rating, or 3 × on a three.

## Winning

After the first possession, swap seats and trackers, flip every player card, and set up again.

After both possessions, the **higher score wins**. Tied? Each player rolls for their final shot: d20 ≤ rating – contest. A make beats a miss.